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ARTICLE

Wars And Rumors Of Wars: Is The World Bracing For Something Bigger?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 26, 2026

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The Middle East is once again holding its breath. Washington and Jerusalem are weighing another strike on Iran. Tehran is warning that any new attack could set the entire region ablaze. American forces are moving, diplomats are leaving, and claims of secret ultimatums and last-minute evacuations are racing across the internet.

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Some of those claims may prove wrong. But the atmosphere they describe is real: the world is preparing for a crisis that could spread far beyond Iran.

Iran Is The Flashpoint

Reports say the United States and Israel have drawn up plans for renewed strikes on Iran, possibly after the U.S. midterm elections. The targets under discussion reportedly include Iran's nuclear facilities, missile and drone forces, and energy infrastructure. Military exercises have included flights over Iraq to practice strike maneuvers. The USS George Washington, operating in the Arabian Sea, has taken on a major delivery of long-range missiles and bunker-buster bombs.

The preparations and public warnings have made one question impossible to ignore: What happens if the bombs start falling again?

President Trump has threatened "another little Epic Fury" and said the United States could "just take all of the oil." Iran's answer has been equally stark. Tehran says a new attack would bring a wider war, with American bases, Gulf neighbors, energy sites and civilian infrastructure all potentially in the line of fire.

The threat now extends beyond oil and military targets. Iranian security officials say Tehran has detailed plans to hit undersea cables that carry internet traffic through the Gulf. Iranian officials have also threatened data centers and other U.S.-linked technology sites. A strike that cuts off communications or disrupts banking and online services could make a regional war felt in ways that reach far beyond the battlefield.

A new U.S. intelligence warning adds to the escalation. A memo says Iranian plots against American personnel and citizens have reached "advanced stages."

Washington has ordered non-emergency personnel and their families to leave Saudi Arabia and adjusted staffing at other diplomatic posts. Those moves come as the United States prepares for the possibility that Americans across the region could become targets.



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The Rumors Are Getting Harder To Ignore

The official warnings are only part of the story. Online reports claim Washington told Iraq's prime minister that a strike could come "in the coming days," amid fears that armed groups in Iraq would join the fight. U.S. Ambassador to Turkey Tom Barrack has also said a strike could happen within days.

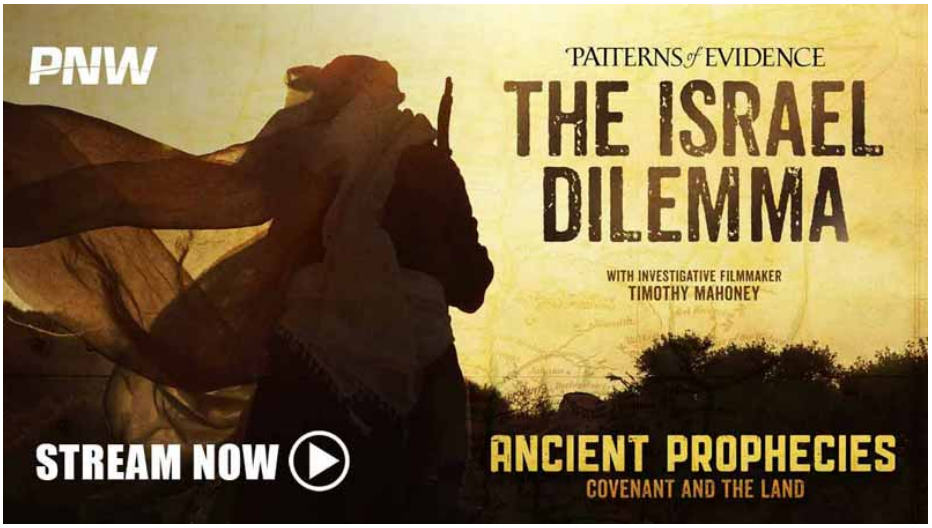
Another claim says Russia has told diplomats in Kuwait, Qatar and Bahrain to prepare to leave before Iran retaliates against U.S. allies. A source in the private-aviation industry says demand for Middle East charter flights has jumped 50 percent, with diplomats, expatriates and even members of a royal family seeking to get out. The account describes people who feel they must leave before missiles fly.

Then there is the reported ultimatum delivered by Pakistan's army chief, Asim Munir. According to reports attributed to the Lebanese newspaper Al-Akhbar, Munir carried a final U.S. demand to Tehran: abandon the nuclear program or face large-scale strikes, including against Pickaxe Mountain. Iran's response, according to its own statements, was that no enriched nuclear material would leave the country and negotiations could not resume until Washington met Tehran's conditions.

Iranian officials say those conditions include seven demands. Iranian media are describing the talks as deadlocked. That is the language of diplomacy running out of road.

Tehran has also sent a warning directly toward Israel. Iran's hardline Kayhan newspaper has called for Israeli nuclear facilities to be targeted if the United States strikes Pickaxe Mountain. The speculation online has already turned to Dimona and possible nuclear-weapons storage sites in northern Israel. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps has warned that Israel could become "uninhabitable for decades."

These are not the words of leaders preparing the public for calm. They are the words of a region where threats are growing more explicit and every new military move is being read as a possible opening shot.



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Israel Faces More Than One Front

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth also made an unannounced visit to Israel and met with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. Hegseth said American forces there were ready to prevent Iran from obtaining a nuclear weapon. Netanyahu has gone further, saying Israel is committed to bringing down Iran's regime and eliminating Hezbollah, after which he says peace with Lebanon can follow.

An Israeli air-force sortie toward Iran has added another layer of intrigue. The flights were described as training and a show of force. One Israeli analysis argued they could also help lull Tehran into complacency before a surprise attack. Whether intended as a warning or something more, the flights have become part of a region where every movement is being scrutinized for what may come next.

And Iran is not Israel's only concern. After an attack near Hebron killed two Israeli soldiers, Netanyahu vowed to hunt Hamas operatives and ordered a wider military operation in Judea and Samaria. Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich demanded a comprehensive campaign, including dismantling the Palestinian Authority. The possibility of renewed conflict now stretches from Iran and Lebanon to Hamas and Judea and Samaria.

Europe Is Preparing, Too

The war in Ukraine is already a brutal reality. Now Europe is preparing for the possibility that conflict and disruption could reach deeper into civilian life. Britain has launched a campaign urging households to keep three days of food, water and basic supplies. Germany has longstanding emergency-supply guidance, and Quebec's government has also urged residents to prepare emergency kits.

Across Europe, the preparations are becoming harder to miss. Finland has rehearsed a crisis involving cyberattacks on power and water systems alongside a missile threat. The European Union is running a major crisis-response exercise. France and Britain have held their first joint exercise involving a simulated nuclear strike mission, with French Rafale jets escorted by British Typhoons.

NATO has been focused on sabotage, drones, cyberattacks and the protection of critical infrastructure. NATO allies reportedly foiled a Russian undersea-cable sabotage plot. Lithuania has increased security around critical sites after a suspected sabotage attempt at a Starlink facility that authorities linked to Russia.

These measures are connected to the war in Ukraine and the growing fear of a wider confrontation with Russia. They also point to a new understanding of what war can look like: not only tanks crossing borders, but power failing, communications going dark and ordinary people being told to prepare for disruption.

Cuba Enters The Conversation

At a Florida rally, Trump turned from Iran to Cuba after a supporter shouted a question about the island. He said the United States would "take care of Cuba on our way back from Iran," describing American warships stopping near the coast and sending Secretary of State Marco Rubio to finish the deal.

The remarks had a joking tone. But moments later, Rubio urged Cubans seeking political change to pursue a “discreet partnership with the CIA.” The CIA’s official account later echoed the appeal. No invasion was announced, but the sequence was striking: a president talking about warships off Cuba, followed by the nation’s top diplomat publicly inviting cooperation with American intelligence.

From Ukraine to Iran, from Israel’s borders to the Caribbean, the map of possible confrontation keeps expanding. The reports, threats and rumors do not all carry the same weight. Together, however, they describe a world where leaders are preparing for conflict, governments are warning their citizens, and the next escalation could reach several fronts at once.

Jesus warned that the world would hear of “wars and rumors of wars.” Those words feel newly urgent when the rumors are arriving alongside military buildups, evacuation orders and leaders openly discussing what they may do in the next conflict.

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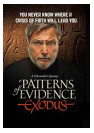


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